Jacobus Acontius — Satan's Stratagems (1565)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This presentation is dedicated to the anonymous translator of 1648, and to the conditional promise he left in his own book. In a London torn by civil war he rendered the first four books into English, and he dedicated that book to Parliament, to Fairfax and Cromwell, and to the Lord Mayor. His promise was conditional, and no more was ever published. The reason is unknown. This dedication follows the folder's own, and honours the labour he did complete.

The author's own terms

“Stratagems of Satan” in Acontius's own sense are not occult devices. They are the dogmatic creeds and controversies that divide the church. Satan's war is waged by turning Christians' zeal, fear, pride, and love of being right against each other, so that persecution and coercion become his instruments. Appended is his letter to Johann Wolf, *De ratione edendorum librorum*, on the publishing of books. It stands in the Latin from 1565, absent from the French translation.

The story

Jacobus Acontius was a jurist, philosopher, theologian, and engineer, born at

Trent about the beginning of the sixteenth century. His birth year is unsettled and is not asserted here. He died in 1566. His own letter to Wolf tells that he spent many years studying law and time in the courts, and took up literature late in life. He settled at Basel in 1557, two months after his friend Francesco Betti, and his first work, *De Methodo* (Basel: Perna, 1558), was dedicated to Betti. Soon after Elizabeth's accession he came to England. An annuity of £60 was granted on 27 February 1560, and naturalisation followed on 8 October 1561. He worked on draining the Plumstead marshes, and in 1564 a commission sent him to report on Berwick's fortifications. That report survives in the Record Office. He is now known chiefly for his contribution to the history of religious toleration.

The work and what survives

Stratagematum Satanae libri octo was first published in Latin at Basel by Pietro Perna in 1565, with the letter to Wolf appended. The Dictionary of National Biography calls the genuine first edition, a quarto, of extreme rarity. Its argument identifies the dogmatic creeds that divide the church as Satan's stratagems, and reduces dogma to a minimum to find a common denominator. Reprints followed, among them Oxford in 1631 and London in 1648. A complete French translation appeared in 1565, the same year as the Latin, wanting the Wolf letter and the index. The gap that follows is therefore an English gap only.

The folder holds “The Complete Eight Books.” Books I–IV reproduce the English of London, 1648, printed by John Macock, from the EEBO-TCP keyed text, spelling lightly modernised, with its 1648 front matter. Books V–VIII are newly Englished from the Oxford 1631 Latin, whose main pagination runs to 426 pages. That rendering is a workman's paragraph-for-paragraph translation from a difficult scan, with bracketed editorial bridges where the impression was too broken for certainty. One leaf of the Latin copy, pages 193–194, in Book IV, is wanting in the scan and does not touch the translation.

Its English fortunes

The translator of 1648 is anonymous on his own title page. Later catalogues have sometimes attributed him to John Goodwin. In his dedication he wrote:

“If this essay shall find acceptance, the Translator intends to go in hand with the remaining Books, God affording life and opportunity.” No more was ever published, and the reason is unknown. If the translator was Goodwin, he lived to about 1665.

After research, no complete English translation of these books has been found; this is, so far as that research reaches, the first Englishing of the second half of *Satan's Stratagems*. The Dictionary of National Biography bibliography corroborates it at that strength: Latin and French entire; English only as the 1648 first-four-books issue.

What completing it would take

The folder's edition is structurally complete, and the remaining work is verification. Books V–VIII must be collated against a clean copy of the Oxford 1631 Latin, resolving every bracketed editorial bridge. The 1648 imprint must be resolved against Wing A443A and the ESTC before any single seller's name is printed, and the Wolf letter's place must be stated explicitly. The translator's record must be held exactly as the record holds it: anonymous, sometimes attributed to John Goodwin, his promise conditional and unkept, the reason unknown.

Sources

- Project folder: `~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/acontius-satans-stratagems-complete/` (p1–p6)
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Dictionary_of_National_Biography,_1885-1900/Acontius,_Jacobus
- https://www.britannica.com/topic/Satanae-stratagemata
- https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/bri/g/giacomo-aconcio.html